

Reflection Paper for the Intersection of Culture and Politics-EHE

Culture, the arts, and politics frequently intersect with one another, and often in ways that may not be immediately obvious. This is the focus of a half-semester-long honors seminar that goes by that name. Pupils in this honors seminar were tasked with reviewing assigned reading materials and taking notes on these reading materials, watching in-class discussions with faculty and other honors pupils, and watching the movie *Fail Safe*.

To begin, multiple reading assignments were given. These included: a Wikipedia article about the topic; a different level.com article entitled, “How Art and Politics Influence and Shape Each Other;” a WideWalls magazine article entitled, “The Strong Relation Between Art and Politics” an Aeon essays article entitled “What does art do?” and a Connecting Point article entitled “What is the Role of Art in Politics?” The Wikipedia article provided an overview of the topic along with examples. “Poets are the unacknowledged legislators of the world,” this is a quote uttered by Percy Bysshe Shelly in *A Defense of Poetry*. Here we see an argument articulated that poets and other members of the creative classes can frequently be highly effective in challenging existing legislation or social norms by marshaling public opinion to change these norms. To continue this thought about challenging social norms, cultural output such as Folk and Protest music characterized the 1960s. Pete Seeger, Joan Baez, and Bob Dylan contained lyrics that criticized police violence, and social conformity and advocated for nuclear disarmament and global diplomacy. The different-level article further expanded upon the use of art by left-of-center political actors for advocacy work. This can be seen in artwork and murals about the plight of the Syrian refugees in 2015. Artwork like this can also be used to portray actions that lead to global warming and the importance of recycling materials that would provide environmental benefits. The great plastic wave by Nic Mac in which a famous Japanese painting

of a tsunami is shown with the white foam of the wave's end being replaced by discarded single-use plastic bags from supermarkets is an example of this. The WideWalls article continued with the common theme of left-leaning activism by discussing the use of art to protest in economic situations. For instance, the enormous power of large multi-national corporations is called into question with the painting *Against Monsanto*, in which two robots are shown amid flowers from a field; this image is making light of the degree to which mechanization and industrialization of the food supply chain is a less natural way of producing food, implying that the end product of the contemporary industrialized food sector, which the Monsanto corporation epitomizes, is less natural for the consumer. The magical-realist Polish film called *Never Gonna Snow Again* in the Aeon article depicts a world in which no snow falls after 2025 to draw attention to Global Warming. The final article written by Ryan McCollum for Connecting Point focuses on the cultural output produced by people with right-leaning political views. This is most noteworthy in music where musicians such as Ted Nugent and Kid Rock are more than happy to articulate their political messaging through the music they compose and perform for their audiences. Ted Nugent in particular is well known for his vocal support of Second Amendment rights.

Next, the class featured a student speaker speaking about his knowledge relating to how culture and politics intersect with one another. The student speaker spoke to us about his trip to a German museum that contained many cultural artifacts from the former Soviet Union and other countries in Europe. In the Soviet Union, this could be seen with murals depicting the struggles of the Proletariat and the grand statues glorifying Lenin and his fellow revolutionaries. In Nazi Germany, paintings were frequently used to extoll the glories of battle and sculptures portrayed what was seen to be the ideal German man or woman. It was also seen as being of critical importance to suppress art that promoted dissent for that would have had the potential to inspire

critical thinking, and thereby resistance against the regime. The erasure of art from a previous ruling regime can be used by a new state to provide closure for the fall of the previous ruling class. For instance, in the former satellite states of the Soviet Union, sculptures of Lenin were gradually torn after the collapse of Communism.

Lastly, in this class pupils watched a film from the 1960s called *Fail Safe*, which provides what may well be described as a textbook example of Culture and Politics intersecting. In this film, the American nuclear deterrent against the Soviet Union is presented. The audience is shown a doomsday scenario in which a technical flaw causes American airmen piloting a B-58 long-haul strategic bomber to be given erroneous orders to drop two thermonuclear warheads on Moscow. This triggered an international incident that eventually resulted in the destruction of New York City. Here, one can see that cultural production, a film, is commenting on the need to control nuclear weaponry better to avoid catastrophic outcomes, which can be achieved through constructive international diplomacy and attention to arms control.

To conclude, Culture and Politics frequently intersect with one another, and that was demonstrated by the class of that name. Multiple articles touching on this subject were reviewed in-depth, multiple faculty lectures were presented and the movie *Fail Safe* was screened. Culture and Politics intersect as culture frequently shapes political beliefs, values, and identities, while political decisions and policies may impact norms, expressions, and practices of political actors, leading to what one may characterize as a complex relationship between the two. Overall, this class proved to be quite rewarding in that I was able to view different issues from an interdisciplinary perspective, which is something I normally do not have the opportunity to work on. These skills will prove useful when analyzing issues requiring knowledge of both business and political science from an interdisciplinary perspective in a future occupation.

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